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Communicating strategic CEO activism to promote employee prosocial behaviors: Understanding the mediating role of employee prosocial sensemaking

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ABSTRACT

The purpose of this research is to explore how CEOs effectively communicate their activism so as to encourage employee prosocial behaviors around social issues. An online experimental study with a 2 (*narrative vs. non-narrative*) x 2 (*promotion- vs. prevention-focused messages*) between-subjects design was conducted with 913 full-time employees (N=913) in the United States. This study uncovered the underlying role of employee prosocial sensemaking, which mediates the effect of narrative messaging in CEO activism communication on employee prosocial behaviors (e.g., employee activism supporting the issue and advocacy for the CEO's activism). This study theoretically extends the scholarship on strategic communication to CEO activism communication in relation to employee prosocial behaviors. The findings also provide practical insight into how corporate leaders can strategically communicate their activism to employees in order to foster positive engagement, thereby contributing to organizational effectiveness as well as the expansion of responsible business practices.

1. Introduction

In this era of increased political polarization and greater visibility of social issues, a larger number of corporations have come to take on a more dynamic, progressive agenda of activism and justice, and the public has turned to these organizations and their leaders to respond to societal concerns and crises (Zheng, 2020). Companies and chief executive officers (hereafter CEOs) are expected to engage in societal issues outside the boundaries of their business (Edelman Connected Crisis Study, 2022). To wit, more than half of American millennials believe that corporate leaders have a responsibility to speak out about important social issues (Weber Shandwick, unitedminds, & KRC Research, 2019). Moreover, employees are more likely to work for a company if it publicly supports and addresses social issues such as racial justice, climate change, and gender equality (Edelman Trust Barometer, 2022).

As corporate practices are reshaped to this end, scholarship is increasingly exploring the dynamics thereof, particularly as they relate to CEO activism (Branicki et al., 2021; Chatterji & Toffel, 2019). In this context, researchers have emphasized strategic leadership communication of prosocial actions to build employee trust and to promote prosocial behaviors by employees, highlighting employee engagement in CEO activism as a collaborative effort (co-construction of meaning) involving various entities and individuals in a social system who are aiming to contribute to positive social changes (Lemon, 2019). Ji and Hong (2023) underscored the importance of emphasizing the societal impacts of employee engagement in CEO activism, which can be assessed through employees' activism participation intentions and advocacy communication. In line with this, the current study takes a perspective that emphasizes the societal impacts of engagement, placing an organization within an ecological framework. This approach centers on societal members engagement as co-construct meaning to address key social issues and contribute to a fully functioning society (Johnston & Taylor, 2018).

Strategic CEO activism communication is an important topic, particularly as it pertains to the impact of the practices on employee engagement and their prosocial behaviors. To encourage prosocial behaviors among employees as the positive influence of CEO activism, it is essential to activate their employee prosocial sensemaking that can be

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achieved when CEO activism is perceived as authentic (i.e., perceived authenticity of CEO activism) and identified as prosocial (i.e., CEO prosocial identity) (Grant et al., 2008; Jin et al., 2024). Nonetheless, existing studies have not fully explored how strategic communication of CEO activism can be implemented to affect employee prosocial sensemaking, in order for them to engage in their prosocial behaviors.

Consequently, the purpose of this study is to explore the effects of CEO activism communication on employees' reactions, specifically their sensemaking of the activism and engaging in prosocial behaviors. By filling this research gap, the findings will offer important insight into how corporate leaders can strategically communicate their activism to employees so as to foster positive engagement through employees' prosocial sensemaking processes, thereby contributing to organizational effectiveness as well as to the expansion of responsible business practices.

2. Literature review

2.1. CEO activism

CEOs are, quite literally, the face of their corporation (Ji & Hong, 2023). In recent years, these corporate leaders have garnered substantial public attention concerning their activism and personal rhetoric around social issues; therefore, these factors are being taken into consideration in organizational scholarship and practice (Branicki et al., 2021). CEO activism can be defined as "corporate leaders speaking out on social and environmental policy issues not related to their company's core business" such as climate change and LGBTQ rights (Chatterji & Toffel, 2019, p. 159). CEO activism is conceptually different from corporate social advocacy (CSA),[1] which involves stakeholders both inside and outside the organization and an overall goal to contribute to sociopolitical public discourse (Gaither & Austin, 2022). CSA comprises organizational-level initiatives taking on controversial social, political, and environmental topics unrelated to their core businesses, whereas CEO activism involves a CEO's personal and public expression of their stance on political and social issues (Hambrick & Wowak, 2019).

Researchers have demonstrated that CEO activism can influence public policy and consumers' feelings about the leader's organization, as well as the issue itself (Chatterji & Toffel, 2019; Larcker et al., 2018). However, further research is needed, particularly empirical studies, as thus far only limited attention has been given to what drives and influences CEOs engaging in communication about such behavior (Branicki et al., 2021). Specifically, there is a dearth of research on how CEO activism should be communicated so as to help employees better make sense of and engage in prosocial behaviors (Ji & Hong, 2023; Lee, 2021).

Recently, Ji and Tao (2024) indicated that effective leadership communication of CEO activism can motivate employees to actively participate in prosocial behaviors, contributing to positive social change. Ji and Hong (2023) also demonstrated that communication of CEO activism can have a significant impact on employees, specifically their external activism motivation and their participation in a CEO's activism campaign. However, the mechanism of how employees make sense of strategically communicated CEO activism in a way that leads to prosocial behaviors is not fully understood. In order to better explicate the effect of communication of CEO activism on employees, this study examines how CEOs can communicate their activism strategically so as to facilitate employees' prosocial behaviors through the latter's sensemaking process.

2.2. CEO activism communication strategies

Researchers have suggested that a CEO's activism message be deliberately designed to be authentic (Jin et al., 2024) and to resonate with their values (Wowak et al., 2022) in order to increase the effectiveness of CEO activism communication. Furthermore, previous research has indicated the impact of different message-framing strategies in enhancing the effectiveness of persuasive messages targeting attitudinal and behavioral changes (Kim & Chon, 2022). In line with this, the current study uses two framing strategies—*narrative style* and *regulatory focus theory*—that have been widely applied in effective corporate communication strategies looking to generate positive societal impact (Kim et al., 2023; Lee et al., 2020).

2.2.1. Narrative messages

Narrative messages are delivered in a story-like format and include personal stories or anecdotes, testimonials, and infotainment content (Kim et al., 2023; Shen et al., 2015). Narratives are defined as "a representation of connected events and characters that has an identifiable structure, is bounded in space and time, and contains implicit or explicit messages about the topic being addressed" (Kreuter et al., 2007, p. 222). The persuasive power of a narrative message can be explained by two theories: *narrative transportation theory* and *exemplification theory* (Bakker et al., 2019). Narrative transportation theory posits that individuals fully engage with and mentally immerse themselves in the story presented by a narrative message, resulting in changes in their attitudes, beliefs, and intentions[2] (Green & Brock, 2000; Slater & Rouner, 2002). Exemplification theory[3] posits that specific narratives can strongly influence individuals' perceptions because specific cases (as examples) can shape and alter the individuals' beliefs and behavioral intentions (Dahlstrom, 2014; Zillmann, 2006).

Researchers have found that narrative messages are perceived as less obtrusive in the context of corporate communication, because they are not overtly persuasive (Van Laer et al., 2019). In effective corporate communication (e.g., CSR communication), strategic storytelling using a narrative style has been suggested as a powerful persuasive communication strategy, as it reduces message resistance (Moyer-Gusé, 2008) while simultaneously increasing affective disposition toward the message (Raney, 2004), thereby ensuring effective communication that induces desirable outcomes (here, positive impacts) (Liang et al., 2018). Previous research has also found that narrative messages can decrease the negative impacts of CSR communication by reducing CSR skepticism (Xu & Kochigina, 2021).

[1] Corporate social advocacy (CSA) "involves corporate support for—or opposition to—controversial social causes or movements, and thus, runs the risk of alienating some stakeholders" (Gaither & Austin, 2022, p. 177). Previous research has suggested that CSA is as a distinct concept from corporate social responsibility (CSR) in terms of their different stances: taking on controversial issues (CSA) versus offering general support to the societal good (CSR) (Overton et al., 2021). In this regard, organizations that engage in CSA often face objections or repercussions from internal and external stakeholders because they take an active stance on controversial social-political issues (Yang et al., 2022). While not a particularly new practice, CSA has gained momentum in recent years given increased consumer expectations, and it emphasizes stakeholders both within and outside the organization with an overall goal to contribute to socio-political public discourse. CSA, along with CSR, tends to be more successful and well-received when there is a clear connection between the company and the advocated cause (Gaither & Austin, 2022).

[2] Slater and Rouner (2002) explained that "absorption in the narrative may motivate deeper processing of a different kind" in the context of narrative processing, facilitating individuals' acceptance of the attitudes and behaviors provided in the message and, in turn, leading to their responses consistent with the intent of the intervention (p. 187).

[3] The exemplification theory explains the persuasive process of narratives as a consequence of heuristics as people tend to either overestimate or underestimate the frequency or likelihood of a situation based on its similarity to a stereotype or other preexisting knowledge (i.e., the representativeness heuristic) or in relation to the ease with which instances or associations come to mind (i.e., the availability heuristic) (Peters et al., 2006; Zillmann, 2006).

2.2.2. Promotion- vs. prevention-focused messages

Regulatory focus theory—centered on the principle that individuals are motivated by the pursuit of pleasure and the avoidance of pain—is increasingly being incorporated into message framing in the context of corporate communication, due to its ability to effectively explain and predict a variety of persuasion processes and subsequent behaviors (Lee & Koo, 2012; Lee et al., 2020). Regulatory focus theory establishes distinct motivational orientations and emphasizes self-regulation toward desired end-states; specifically, it proposes that self-regulation related to strong ideals indicates *a promotion focus*, while self-regulation related to strong 'oughts' indicates *a prevention focus* (Higgins, 1997, 2000). Promotion-focused individuals are motivated to achieve an ideal state—i.e., pursue what matches a desired end--states—while prevention-focused individuals are likely to be vigilant in preventing problems and to prioritize safety and non-losses—i.e., avoid what does not match a desired end-state (Crowe & Higgins, 1997).

In the context of corporate communication, researchers have suggested that message effectiveness can be enhanced by understanding the motivational orientation induced by message framing—which can emphasize either the pursuit of a desired/positive outcome (*promotion-focused orientation*) or the avoidance of an undesired/negative outcome (*prevention-focused orientation*) (Lin & Shen, 2012). Lee and Aaker (2004) revealed the important role of persuasive messages with different regulatory foci (promotion focus vs. prevention focus) in shaping favorable attitudes toward a product. Lee et al. (2020) demonstrated that promotion-focused messages related to a company's initiatives on a social issue can be more convincing and perceived as less manipulative than prevention-focused messages, resulting in more positive brand attitudes toward the company.

2.3. The impact of CEO activism on employee prosocial behaviors

Prosocial behaviors—in the form of helping, sharing, donating, and volunteering—are either positive social acts that create and maintain the well-being and integrity of others, or discretionary activities supporting non-profit organizations that benefit others and improve societal welfare (Brief & Motowidlo, 1986; Feng et al., 2020). Scholarship has explored how participation in prosocial activities could be undertaken in order to attain power and capital, obtain legitimacy, and to influence employee commitment (van Aaken et al., 2013; Zadek, 2004). McKeever et al. (2019) operationalized specific prosocial behaviors: volunteering (e.g., volunteering the time to support the issue), providing financial support (e.g., making a financial contribution related to the issue), and other forms of advocacy (e.g., attending a march or rally related to the issue). Researchers have recommended understanding the important factors that can induce specific prosocial behaviors that are not required but are considered to be critical for organizations that rely on support from a wide range of different publics such as donors, volunteers, and advocates (McKeever et al., 2019; Tidwell, 2005).

In the context of organizational behavior, prosocial behaviors are defined as helpful behaviors performed by employees that are directed toward other entities or stakeholders, including the organization itself (Malhotra & Ackfeldt, 2016). In other words, prosocial behaviors, or actions within the organizations that are *other-regarding* rather than *self-regarding*, benefit the organization or the work unit (Barry & Wilkinson, 2006). In other words, organizational prosocial behaviors encompass actions that go beyond formal role expectations, such as cooperating with co-workers, taking action when necessary to protect the organization from unexpected danger, recommending improvements, and speaking favorably about the organization to outsiders, which are important for effective organizational functioning. These behaviors illustrate a form of prosocial behavior where employees spontaneously and voluntarily act to support the organization's success (Brief & Motowidlo, 1986). In this sense, *employee prosocial behaviors* are an extra-role and relatively discretionary form of behavior that comprises supportive behaviors that are directed toward their organizations (Tsarenko et al., 2018).

Empirical research has highlighted the significance and role of internal communication in promoting and fostering prosocial behaviors among employees because a company's efforts to keep employees informed about plans and progress positively influences employees' decision to engage in their prosocial behaviors for the benefit of the organization (Dedahanov et al., 2015; Malhotra & Ackfeldt, 2016). Therefore, this study examines employee prosocial behaviors in response to CEO activism communication, as these indicate employees' behavioral engagement (Lee & Tao, 2021).

2.3.1. Employee prosocial behaviors: employee activism and advocacy

In terms of specific employee prosocial behavior, this study addresses *employee advocacy behavior* and *employee activism* as crucial behavioral outcomes that support CEO activism communication (Lee & Dong, 2023; Lee & Tao, 2021). In the literature, both *advocacy* and *activism* have been recognized as prosocial behaviors (Jin et al., 2024), as they aim not only to involve diverse people and groups in bringing attention to an issue but also to influence the decision-making process in support of bringing about change (McKeever et al., 2023). However, previous research has underscored distinctions between both the two concepts: advocacy, which operates within a system alongside and in support of organizations (organization-oriented behavior), involves persuasion, attitudinal changes, and efforts to gain support for ideas, whereas activism often centers around more direct or forceful actions, addressing problematic conditions, and confronting challenges, working externally to influence a system as issue-oriented behavior (De Moya & Bravo, 2016; McKeever et al., 2023).

Employee advocacy behavior is considered part of the broader concept of organizational citizenship behavior (OCB),[4] as it is a voluntary step beyond employees' job requirements that is taken to help their organization (Walden and Kingsley Westerman, 2018). Specifically, it refers to employees' voluntary behaviors in actively promoting or defending their companies (including their products, services, and brands) through word-of-mouth communication (Fullerton, 2011; Men, 2014). Employees function as advocates when they voluntarily endorse or share favorable recommendations with their friends, family, acquaintances, and potential employees in both offline and online settings outside of their organization, without receiving direct requests or any explicit rewards (e.g., financial compensation) (Walden et al., 2018). Kim and Rhee (2011) conceptualized employee advocacy behavior as positive megaphoning, which refers to employees' voluntary behaviors of sharing and forwarding positive information about their organization and management with those around (i.e., friends or families) and defending their company against external critics. Previous researchers have emphasized the advantage of utilizing employee advocacy behavior as a unique internal communication strategy to increase organizations' competitive advantage (Tsarenko et al., 2018). Such behavior has the potential to improve an organization's public image (Miles & Mangold, 2014), create opportunities to boost sales (Morhart et al., 2011), and contribute to overall organizational performance and organizational success (Podsakoff et al., 2000).

In addition to employee advocacy behavior, researchers have suggested examining employees' activism intentions or collective actions, to highlight the societal impact of employee behaviors (Ji & Hong, 2023; Lee & Tao, 2021). Employees' activism behaviors are conceptually linked to *collective action*, which refers to "actions by group members that are aimed at improving the conditions of the group as a whole" and involves behaviors on the part of an in-group that are directed at improving the conditions of the entire group (Van Zomeren et al., 2012, p. 181). Thus, collective action is more likely to take place when

[4] Organizational citizenship behavior (OCB) consists of voluntary efforts by employees that surpass formal job duties, are discretionary, and are not explicitly acknowledged or rewarded by the organization (Organ, 1990).

individuals believe they can make a difference and closely identify them with relevant social groups (McGarty et al., 2014). Employee collective action aims to improve the overall status of a disadvantaged group or to maintain the status quo, and it is consistently recognized as a more effective approach for reducing inequality and promoting social justice (Becker & Wright, 2011; Jost et al., 2017). In this regard, employees' activism behaviors in this study mean their willingness to engage in legal and non-violent actions and include expressing their intention to participate in a public rally, protest, or demonstration in support of organizations that advocate for social issues related to disadvantage groups, as well as donating money or volunteering time to organizations support the political and legal rights of disadvantaged groups, such as writing petitions, distributing flyers, and recruiting others (Ji & Hong, 2023; Moskalenko & McCauley, 2009).

While organizations may gain social and economic benefits from employee prosocial behaviors, motivating employees to engage in such behaviors is challenging due to their voluntary nature, as they go beyond formal job requirements and expectations (Tsarenko et al., 2018). To this end, it is imperative for CEOs to understand how their communication practices can foster employee prosocial behaviors. Researchers have underscored the important role of leaders' advocacy for social issues in promoting organizational members' engagement, and especially in fostering employees' prosocial behaviors (Ji & Hong, 2023; Yang et al., 2022). However, much remains unknown about how CEO activism communication strategies promote different forms of employee prosocial behaviors.

2.4. Employee prosocial behaviors: outcomes of CEO activism communication strategies

In the context of corporations' prosocial communication, utilizing a narrative style has been suggested as an effective message strategy for engaging targeted publics and for shaping positive attitudes and supportive behavioral intentions (Boukes & LaMarre, 2021; Kim et al., 2023). Weber et al. (2006) suggested that narrative messages are more persuasive than statistical messages in encouraging individuals to advocate for organ donation (e.g., signing an organ donor card). Du and Vieira (2012) highlighted the importance of narratives as a more persuasive strategy for increasing the credibility of CSR information and resulting in positive perceptions and favorable attitudes toward a company implementing CSR initiatives. Dhanesh and Nekmat (2019) demonstrated that narrative-based messaging can improve communication outcomes, such as fostering favorable attitudes and supportive behavioral intentions toward the organization. Boukes and LaMarre (2021) also found that a narratively-rich written message about a company's water sustainability program increased positive word-of-mouth behaviors among the publics.

Previous research has described the positive impacts of narratives on attitudinal and behavioral changes in terms of *narrative transportation theory,* which explains that individuals become more emotionally and personally connected to a message when they are transported into the story (Green & Brock, 2000; Slater & Rouner, 2002). Accordingly, researchers have demonstrated that CSR communication with narrative messaging can lead to positive attitudes and behaviors toward companies through supportive behaviors such as purchase intentions and interests in employment (Boukes & LaMarre, 2021), as well as advocacy for the companies and engagement through positive word-of-mouth (Kim & Chon, 2022).

In a similar vein, recent studies have applied narrative transportation theory to create narrative messages promoting prosocial behaviors. Hu et al. (2023) suggested that narrative message designs involving with a plot and characters in the story increases acceptance of the messages by the communication's receivers and leads them to engage in prosocial behaviors related to water reuse. Kim et al. (2023) demonstrated the positive impact of narrative messages in reducing consumers' skepticism toward a company's sustainable initiatives, which in turn facilitated their participation in the company's sustainability campaign. Given these findings, it is reasonable to expect that CEOs' narrative messages can effectively induce employee prosocial behaviors that are aligned with the delivered message. Therefore, this study suggests the following hypotheses:

H1. *CEO activism communication using a narrative style will likely have a more positive impact on external employee prosocial behaviors, such as employee activism supporting the issue (H1a) and employee advocacy for the CEO's activism (H1b), than CEO activism communication using a non-narrative style.*

In addition, previous research has indicated that promotion-focused employees, who strive to attain their ideals through advancement and accomplishment, are likely to demonstrate high levels of achievement, openness to new ideas, and willingness to take risks, which contributes to effective job performance (De Cremer et al., 2009; Wallace et al., 2009). In contrast, prevention-focused employees—who are concerned with duties, obligations, and anxiety-based emotions—tend to focus on safety attainment by minimizing errors, which may be incompatible with extra-role behaviors (Wallace & Chen, 2006). Crowe and Higgins (1997) found that regulatory focus can independently influence behavioral patterns among employees in task performance and problem-solving; they found that participants with a promotion focus were more likely to perform better with a tendency to ensure hits than those with a prevention focus, who were more inclined to ensure correct rejections and quit readily. Furthermore, Chen et al. (2020) found that employees who tend to take a positive perspective toward achievement (promotion focus) are more likely to share knowledge with other co-workers in the pursuit of potential gains sharing (e.g., exchanging, contributing, and donating knowledge).

Lanaj et al. (2012) corroborated that self-regulation through a promotion focus was strongly related to employee extra-role behaviors for their organizations such as OCB compared to self-regulation through a prevention focus, which was not associated with such employee behaviors. In line with this, researchers have suggested that organizational leaders seeking to optimize the benefits of OCB should induce a promotion focus among their employees, because promotion focused employees (e.g., emphasis on learning and advancement) can facilitate the positive impacts of engaging in OCB on well-being, while prevention-focused employees (e.g., attention to the severity of making errors and mistakes at work) engaging in OCB are likely to see reduced well-being (Kark and van Dijk, 2007; Koopman et al., 2015).

In the same vein, researchers have shown that persuasive message framing can evoke regulatory focus in order to encourage positive behaviors (e.g., Bhatnagar & McKay-Nesbitt, 2016; Lin & Shen, 2012). Kim (2006) revealed that campaign messages framed by the different regulatory foci are effective in inducing behavioral changes. Lin and Shen (2012) found that a promotion-focused message was more persuasive when generating favorable brand attitudes and purchase intentions among customers. Furthermore, Bhatnagar and McKay-Nesbitt (2016) discovered that individuals who encounter promotion-focused pro-environmental content were more inclined to engage in the prosocial behaviors recommended in the content. Bullard and Penner (2017) also found that a promotion focus is a more effective antecedent of philanthropic behavior than a prevention focus, as it can increase individuals' motivation to participate in philanthropic activities.

Moreover, researchers have demonstrated that a leader's regulatory focus shapes the regulatory focus of followers as supervisors' promotion-focused messages and behaviors can motivate subordinates' promotion-focused motivations (Johnson et al., 2017). In the workplace, employees with high promotion-focused motivation are likely to associated with extra-role behaviors (e.g., OCB) as this focus value pursuing resource-generating opportunities, motivating employees to direct their efforts toward promoting desired outcomes by pursuing opportunities to grow, gain, or achieve aspirations (Higgins et al., 1994). In this sense, Neubert et al. (2008) provided empirical evidence that when leaders'

messages activate employees' promotion focus, they are likely to participate in helping-oriented extra-role behaviors in the workplace. Furthermore, Gamache et al. (2020) discovered that CEOs' promotion-focused messages in their annual letters tend to inspire stakeholders to participate in socially-oriented activism, encouraging management to adopt certain policies and practices related to environmental, community, consumer, or employee well-being. Therefore, this study proposes the following hypotheses:

H2. *CEO activism communication using a promotion-focused message will likely have a more positive impact on external employee prosocial behaviors, such as employee activism supporting the issue (H2a) and employee advocacy for the CEO's activism (H2b), than CEO activism communication using a prevention-focused message.*

2.5. Mediating role of employee prosocial sensemaking

2.5.1. Employee prosocial sensemaking process: interpretation and identification

Organizational sensemaking was first introduced by Weick (1995), who argued that individual employees actively try to make sense of events within their place of work (particularly events deemed equivocal), resulting in their own interpretations of these occurrences (Vlachos et al., 2017). In organizational theory, the concept of sensemaking explains how employees create an environment in their organization through their perceptions (perceived environment) and engage in behaviors based on perceived external and internal cues (Smircich & Stubbart, 1985; Weick, 1995). As employees take in events and messages in their organizational environments, they first question what might be going on or what something might mean, and then—equally important—they ask the question: *what do I do next*? This implies that sensemaking must end in a state of action (Weick et al., 2005). In an example related to this study, if employees are given the opportunity to participate in corporate giving or volunteer programs, they engage in prosocial sensemaking and, ultimately, tend to view their employer more positively, resulting in a greater sense of organizational identification (Rodell et al., 2020).

The concept of sensemaking has been widely applied to organizations' CSR practices. Focusing on organizations' relationships with stakeholders and the world at large, Basu and Palazzo (2008) emphasized a process of organizational sensemaking, which differentiates organizational character into three dimensions: what firms think (identity), what firms say (justification), and how firms tend to behave (commitment). Aguinis and Glavas (2019) emphasized the concept of employee sensemaking in prioritizing employees in organizations' CSR practices, focusing on how employees—as proactive and intentional agents actively interpreting and shaping their environments—can experience meaningfulness in their work.

Prosocial sensemaking has emerged as another line of this approach involving the sensemaking concept; it aims to understand how employees perceive and interpret both personal and organizational actions as well as how they identify as caring (Grant et al., 2008). Grant et al. (2008) suggested *a prosocial sensemaking model*, which postulates that employees make sense of their company's prosocial actions by perceiving them as such (prosocial interpretation) and then extending this interpretation to identification of the company as prosocial. According to the prosocial sensemaking model, when a company engages in prosocial actions for employees, employees are likely to perceive the company's actions as caring, then generalize this interpretation to a prosocial identity with the company, thereby enhancing their commitment to the company (Raub, 2017; Song & Ferguson, 2023). Thus, the interplay of employees' interpretations based on their perceptions and their identifications is crucial to prosocial sensemaking mechanisms (Grant et al., 2008; Weick et al., 2005).

Moreover, literature on leadership has suggested that CEOs are salient sources of cues that can help employees understand the leaders' positions on a contentious societal issue and can encourage employees to attach symbolic meaning to leaders' words and actions (Corley & Gioia, 2004; Wowak et al., 2022). In light of a CEO's social actions (CEO activism), it is essential to activate employees' perceptions or interpretations of their CEO's social actions, as this is an important antecedent that facilitates employees' prosocial sensemaking processes (Grant et al., 2008; Jin et al., 2024). Researchers have suggested that CEOs' social actions or activism can enhance the perceived authenticity of their leadership (Appels, 2023); this is because CEO activism behaviors not only exhibit self-awareness, in espousing their political values are their own (Nalick et al., 2016), but also demonstrate relational transparency to stakeholders by openly presenting their political convictions (Hambrick & Wowak, 2021). A CEO's activism also invites challenges to their position by sparking public discourse on social issues, which reflects increased levels of balanced processing (Bhagwat et al., 2020), does not directly relate to the company's operations, and often involves financial disincentives (Wettstein & Baur, 2016).

Previous research relying on social identity theory has indicated that authentic CEO activism is likely to lead employees or consumers to identify themselves with the organization (*organizational identification*) (Jin et al., 2024; Kim et al., 2018). Organizational identification[5] refers to individuals' perception or sense of belonging to an organization; it involves the development of a shared identity and values between employees and their organization (Ashforth & Mael, 1989). Past scholarship has suggested that employees, as individuals, hold prosocial identities, seeing themselves as caring and giving individuals (Aquino & Reed, 2002). At the organizational level, employees also create and maintain a company prosocial identity when they perceive the company's contributions as caring and then incorporate this interpretation to their views of the company. For employees, the creation and maintenance of these identities is extremely important as the company prosocial identity can lead to their attitudinal and behavioral commitment (Grant et al., 2008; Raub, 2017).

Authenticity generally refers to being true to one's personality, character, or core values, characterized by being real, truthful, genuine, consistent, and sincere, rather than being dishonest, deceptive, artificial, and manipulative (Men, 2021). With regard to the organizational behavior that incorporates authenticity into organizational identity, perceived authenticity has been highlighted, meaning organizations are expected to act genuinely and avoid manipulating their publics (Henderson & Brookhart, 1996; Shen & Kim, 2012). In a similar vein, perceived authenticity has been recognized as a key attribute for effective leadership communication, which positively promotes employees' extra role behaviors such as suggesting new ideas for improvement and helping new colleagues in the workplace (Men, 2021). In terms of the prosocial communication context, Jin et al. (2024) defined perceived authenticity of CEO activism as "the degree to which a CEO's advocacy engagement is considered genuine and original" (p. 593).

Kim et al. (2018) found that perceived authenticity in their CEO amplified employees' identification with the organization, which motivates CSR practices. In terms of prospective employees, those who perceive the CEO's activism as a form of authentic leadership are likely to find the organization an attractive potential employer and to pursue

[5] The concept of organizational identification originated from *social identity theory*, which explicates how people classify themselves and others into various social categories, such as organizational memberships and age cohorts (Tajfel & Turner, 1985). According to social identity theory, social classification helps the individuals define themselves in social environment through their self-concept, which includes a personal identity and social identification (Turner, 1982). Specifically, social identification refers to "the perception of oneness with or belongingness to some human aggregate" (Ashforth & Mael, 1989, p. 21). To this end, organizational identification is a specific form of social identification, as individuals may derive their social identity not only from the organization but also from their work groups (Ashforth & Mael, 1989).

job opportunities under the CEO (Appels, 2023). If consumers perceive their personal values as aligned with a CEO's activist behavior, the result is an increasing sense of identification and a higher intent to purchase (Jin et al., 2024). This is particularly true for younger generations (e.g., Millennials, Gen Z), who value leaders who are more oriented toward people rather than tasks and organizational mission, and who prioritize value-aligned leadership behaviors (Maier et al., 2015). Given these findings, it is reasonable to posit that the key characteristics of perceived authenticity—including value alignment and morality—of a CEO's activism communication can lead to enhanced identification with CEO activism among employees. Based on the empirical evidence of employee prosocial mechanisms, perceived activism authenticity can be considered an important antecedent for prosocial identity in the context of effective CEO activism for employee prosocial behaviors. Therefore, this study puts forth the following hypothesis:

H3. *A CEO's perceived activism authenticity will positively affect CEO prosocial identity (employee identification with CEO activism as a prosocial action).*

2.5.2. Mediating role of employee prosocial sensemaking for employee prosocial behaviors

Extant research has indicated that employees who attribute a positive prosocial identity to their organization tend to have greater self-esteem as a member of the organization, which in turn enhances their commitment to the organization (Bartel, 2001; Greening & Turban, 2000). Grant (2007) suggested that engaging in discretional behaviors, including prosocial behaviors, can function as a way for employees who make sense of their organization's CSR to find meaningfulness in their work. Furthermore, researchers have demonstrated the importance of employees' sensemaking processes in shaping their attributions, as an instrumental process that helps employees "construct, update, and correct their own perception" of their firm's CSR motives, thereby likely enhancing employee advocacy (Vlachos et al., 2017, p. 1112). Zhou et al. (2017) highlighted the active role of leaders in creating and maintaining a prosocial image (through their perceived prosocial behaviors) to encourage employees' constructive suggestions or speaking-up behaviors (i.e., employee prosocial behaviors). Tsarenko et al.'s (2018) study also indicated that an employee's level of identification with and involvement in their organization can be a strong underlying mechanism fostering employee advocacy behaviors.

Lee and Tao (2021) discovered the positive associations between CEO activism and employee advocacy, suggesting that employees are likely to be motivated to share positive information about their company in their personal networks when they perceive their CEO's actions as morally right. Yin et al. (2021) also argued that employee prosocial behaviors might be performed as a response to the perception of an organization's implementation of environmental CSR practices and environmental activities. Researchers have demonstrated that CEOs' or organizational activism can produce positive organizational outcomes, such as employee support for the company and its leaders, through *social learning theory*—which emphasizes the importance of direct experience in the learning process, specifically observation of others' behaviors and their consequences (Bandura, 1986; Brown et al., 2005; Ji & Tao, 2024). Brown et al. (2005) argued that leaders' behaviors are an important source of role-modeling for employees. Recently, Ji and Tao (2024) applied social learning theory to explain how employees' behaviors are influenced by their observations of their CEOs' behaviors, which can occur through the CEO's communication addressing sociopolitical issues and advocating for positive social change.

Building on this idea in terms of strategic communication of CEO activism, it is possible that employees' prosocial sensemaking—through their perceived activism authenticity and prosocial identity—can effectively mediate the impact of organizational leaders' activist communication on employee prosocial commitments and behaviors within and outside the company. This is because employees can better understand which behaviors are expected and encouraged by observing the actions of CEOs (Neubert et al., 2009). Thus, this study posits the following hypotheses:

H4. *Employee prosocial sensemaking will positively mediate the effects of CEO activism strategies on external employee prosocial behaviors, such as employee activism supporting the issue (H4a) and employee advocacy for the CEO's activism (H4b).*

Based on the literature, this study proposed the theoretical models depicted in Fig. 1.

3. Methods

A 2 (*narrative* vs. *non-narrative*) x 2 (*prevention-focused* vs. *promotion-focused message*) experimental study with a between-subjects design was conducted in the United States.

3.1. Participants

The total sample comprised 913[6] (N=913) full-time employees, with almost half of the participants being women (n = 449, 49.2 %). On average, participants were middle-aged (M = 44.75 years, SD = 14.45), although ages ranged from 18 to 83 years. Most of participants identified their ethnicity as White (79.7 %, n = 728), followed by Black (10.6 %, n = 97), Latino (4.4 %, n = 40), Asian (3.6 %, n = 33), and other races (e.g., Native American) (1.7 %, n = 15). Nearly one-third of the participants had a bachelor's degree (31.4 %, n = 287), followed by those with some postgraduate schooling or a post-graduate degree (26.2 %, n = 239); almost 40 % of participants had either a two-year associate's degree or similar level (28.0 %, n = 156) or a high school degree or less (14.3 %, n = 131).

3.2. Stimuli development

For the stimulus materials, four fictitious CEO activism statements regarding racial discrimination were created using variations in *narrative style* and *regulatory focus messaging*. To ensure ecological validity, these statements were developed using real examples of the most advocated social issue (racial discrimination), identified from a brief content analysis of CEO public statements from Fortune 500 companies published in 2017–2023. Two independent experts—an experienced CEO of a local public relations firm, and a corporate communications professor with more than a decade of professional experience in public relations—reviewed, edited, and confirmed the statements with respect to appropriate writing style.

For the variations in style, a first-person narrative message from the CEO (e.g., 'I') was used for the narrative style conditions, and a corporate statement from the CEO (e.g., 'we') was used for the non-narrative style conditions. The conditions with a narrative message used a specific story format: it highlighted the CEO's unique characteristics, with personal motivations and feelings as well as personal life events (e.g., "my parents raised me to believe that…"), and it that included the CEO's personal experiences with and commitment to racial equity and justice (e.g., "I am passionate about the racial justice issue…"). In contrast, the non-narrative condition presented a corporate statement from the CEO regarding initiatives on the issue ("We are committed to diversity, inclusion, and equity…"), along with official business core values (e.g., "Two of our core values are Respect and Integrity, which are integral in how we conduct business"). Specific actions and statistical information (e.g., pledge $5 million to support…) were identical across the

[6] According to a priori power analysis for linear multiple regression for four conditions and eight predictors, using G-power software effect size (f^2) = 0.02, type I error rate = 0.05, and power = 0.80, a minimum sample size of 800 participants was needed.

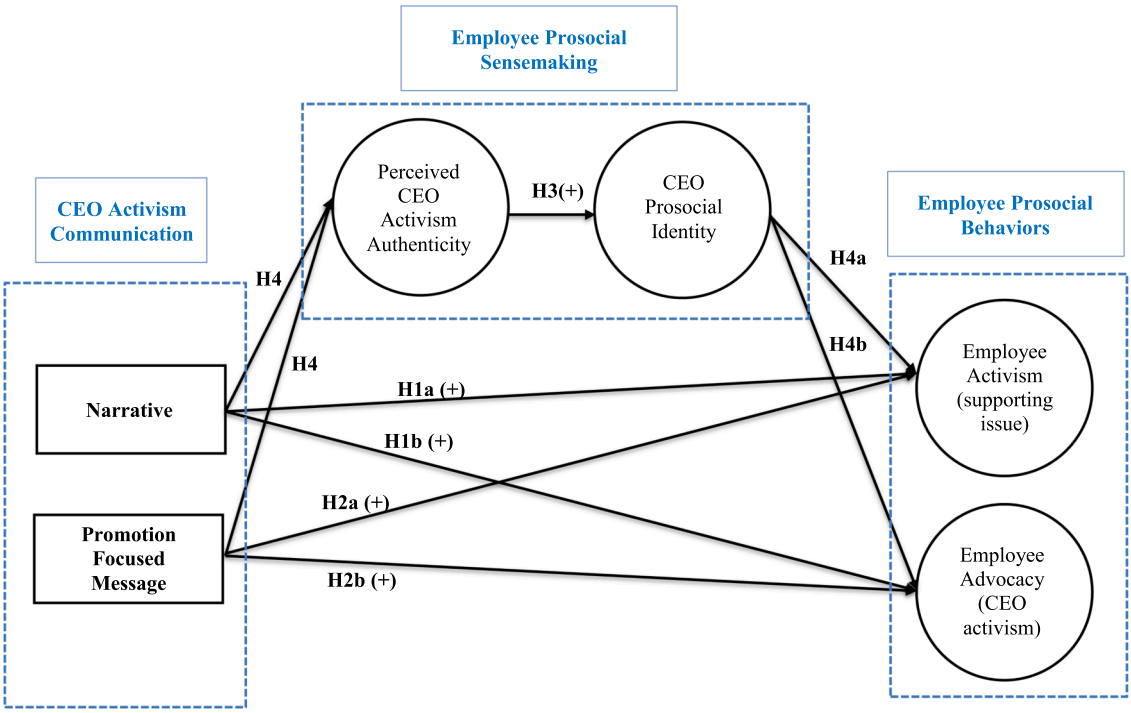


Fig. 1. A proposed model of CEO activism communication for external employee prosocial behaviors. H4(a&b): Mediation effects of employee prosocial sensemaking between CEO activism communication and employee prosocial behaviors.

conditions, as these could be controlled (see Appendix).

For variations in regulatory focus messaging, the messages in the *promotion-focused* conditions were concerned with achievement and emphasized self-regulation toward positive outcomes (e.g., "To promote racial equity and justice in our society…"), the messages in the *prevention-focused message* conditions were concerned with protection and safety and emphasized self-regulation to avoid negative outcomes (e.g., "To prevent systematic racial injustice and inequity in our society…") (Lee et al., 2020). (see Appendix).

3.3. Procedure

The entire research protocol, including the questionnaire and the ethical considerations for participants, was approved by the Institutional Review Board (IRB) at a large university in the United States Midwest. The global online survey firm Dynata, which maintains 1.5 million panels in the U.S., recruited full-time employees to participate via a web-based study link that contained a questionnaire and an informed consent form. Upon providing voluntary consent, participants first answered questions assessing their qualifications, such as their intentions to provide their best answers. Then, participants were randomly assigned to one of the four experimental conditions, read the respective CEO statement, and answered questions measuring all the dependent variables—perceived CEO activism authenticity, CEO prosocial identity, employee activism supporting the issue, and employee advocacy for CEO activism—as well as control variables and demographic information. At the end of the questionnaire, participants were debriefed that the CEO statements were fictitious and had been created solely for the purpose of the study.

A pretest ($N = 88$) was conducted to ensure the study's manipulation[7] and randomization and to assess the study procedure. The pretest found that manipulation was successful, and the randomization was effectively implemented, with balanced groups. The pretest also evaluated the accuracy and believability of the fictitious statements as well as the clarity, understandability, and relevance of the instructions and questions. Participants in the pre-test reported that the fictitious CEO statements were accurate ($M = 5.45$, $SD = 1.74$) and believable ($M = 5.44$, $SD = 1.72$), while finding all questions and instructions to be clear ($M = 6.16$, $SD = 1.21$), understandable ($M = 5.99$, $SD = 1.37$), and relevant ($M = 5.80$, $SD = 1.48$), with answers provided on a 7-point semantic differential scale ranging from inaccurate, unbelievable, unclear, confusing, or irrelevant (1) to accurate, believable, clear, understandable, or relevant (7). In short, no issues concerning randomization or the study procedure were identified in the pretest.

Following the pretest, the main test ($N = 913$) was conducted with participants who did not participate in the pretest. In the main test,

[7] The manipulation checks in the pre-test revealed that participants who received the narrative message were more likely to perceive that the message included a personal story of what the CEO is passionate about and believes ($M_{narrative} = 5.71$, $SD_{narrative} = 1.23$) than those who were exposed to a non-narrative message ($M_{non\text{-}narrative} = 4.30$, $SD_{non\text{-}narrative} = 1.90$), and the result was statistically significant, $t(88) = 4.13$, $p < .001$. For regulatory focus, messages, participants who received prevention-focused messages ($M_{prevention\text{-}focused} = 5.86$, $SD_{prevention\text{-}focused} = 1.31$) were more likely to rate the message as seeking to prevent negative outcomes (preventing systematic racial injustice and inequity) than were participants who read promotion-focused messages (promoting racial equity and justice) ($M_{promotion\text{-}focused} = 4.87$, $SD_{promotion\text{-}focused} = 2.01$), $t(88) = 2.70$, $p < .01$.

participants who did not spend sufficient time (minimum time: 8 minutes) or who spent an excessively long time (more than 60 minutes) were excluded from the data analysis (Sheehan, 2018). The participants' attention was also checked vi a question for this purpose, and all participants provided the correct answer (100 %) in the main test. All participants in both tests received a monetary reward (specifically, gift cards in the amount of $4.50) as compensation for their participation.

3.4. Measures

All measurement items used in this study were adopted from previous research and were measured on a 7-point Likert scale, from 1 ('strongly disagree' or 'not at all') to 7 ('strongly agree' or 'very much'). To understand the employee prosocial sensemaking process, perceived CEO activism authenticity and CEO prosocial identity (mediators) were assessed according to Grant et al.'s (2008) prosocial sensemaking model. Perceived CEO activism authenticity (M = 5.50, SD = 1.37) was measured using eight items (α =.96) (e.g., *the CEO's actions are genuine*) from Alhouti et al. (2016), and CEO prosocial identity (M = 5.43, SD = 1.55) was measured using three items (α =.94) (e.g., *I see the CEO as caring*) from Grant et al. (2008).

Employee activism intention supporting the issue (M = 4.60, SD = 1.91) was measured using four items (α = 95) (e.g., *I would donate money to an organization or group that advocates this issue: racial justice and equity*) from Ji and Hong (2023), and employee advocacy for the CEO's activism (M = 5.26, SD = 1.63) was measured using four items (α = 96) (e.g., *I would speak favorably about the CEO's action in public*) from Walden and Westerman (2018).

For control variables, this study included political ideology and prior history with CEO activism. Social issues can be polarizing and intertwined with individuals' political ideologies (Coombs & Holladay, 2018), and Lee and Tao (2021) found that political ideology is a significant factor affecting attitudes and advocative behavior regarding CEO activism. Political ideology was measured by a question asking the participant to self-rate their political orientation on a 7-point scale, from very conservative (1) to moderate (4) to very liberal (7) (M = 4.19, SD = 1.96). For the second control variable (prior history with CEO activism), researchers have suggested social learning theory (Bandura, 1986) as a theoretical framework for understanding effective leadership that motivates employees to engage in prosocial behaviors aligned with leaders' actions (Jiang et al., 2019). The literature on attitude also has indicated that the direct experience with an attitude object can increase its influence on behavior, due to the accessibility in memory of the guiding mental representation in one's memory (e.g. Fazio & Zanna, 1981). Thøgersen (2002) indicated that direct experience with an attitude object can increase the likelihood that the personal norm will guide behavior in a similar situation involving the attitude object. Prior history of CEO activism was measured by asking whether the participant's CEO had taken actions on any social issues, with answers rated on a 7-point scale from NO (1) to YES, more than five times (7) (M = 4.24, SD = 2.13).

4. Results

4.1. Manipulation checks

The randomization and manipulations were successful. In terms of randomization, each condition had nearly equal sample sizes (i.e., ranging from 225 to 232), and the demographic characteristics of age, gender, education, income, and ethnicity were well-balanced across the four conditions, with no significant differences (p >.05). The manipulations for the different conditions were effective as intended. Participants who received the narrative message were more likely to perceive that the message included a personal story of what the CEO is passionate about and believes ($M_{narrative}$ = 5.93, $SD_{narrative}$ = 1.93) than those who were exposed to a non-narrative message ($M_{non\text{-}narrative}$ = 4.85, $SD_{non\text{-}narrative}$ = 1.35), and the result was statistically significant, t(911) = 9.78, p <.001. For regulatory focus, participants who received prevention-focused messages ($M_{prevention\text{-}focused}$ = 5.63, $SD_{prevention\text{-}focused}$ = 1.52) were more likely to rate the message as seeking to prevent negative outcomes (preventing systematic racial injustice and inequity) than were participants who read promotion-focused messages (promoting racial equity and justice) ($M_{promotion\text{-}focused}$ = 5.41, $SD_{promotion\text{-}focused}$ = 1.67), t(911) = 2.06, p <.05.

4.2. Dimensionality checks

Confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) was performed with all endogenous variables measured with multiple items—employee prosocial sensemaking (perceived CEO activism authenticity and CEO prosocial identity), and employee prosocial behaviors (employee activism supporting issue and advocacy for the CEO's activism)—to ensure unidimensionality. The models demonstrated a good fit for employee prosocial behaviors, χ^2 (135, N = 913) = 381.717, χ^2/df = 2.828, p <.001, CFI =.989, TLI =.986, SRMR =.026, RMSEA =.045, PLCOSE = 0.947 [.04,.05], meeting the acceptability criteria set by Hu and Bentler (1999) and Hair et al. (2018). For the construct validity and composite reliability of all measurement items, the CFA models revealed that the construct validity (CR >.70, standardized factor loading >.50, AVE >.50) and the discriminant validity (AVE > ASV) of the proposed measurement models were successfully established according to Hair et al.'s (2018) criteria (see Tables 1 and 2).

4.3. Hypothesis testing

To examine the proposed structural models and to test the hypotheses, this study conducted a bias-corrected bootstrapping procedure (N = 5000) with 95 % confidence intervals in structural equation modeling (SEM) to validate the mediation effects of employee prosocial sensemaking (Byrne, 2016). Before conducting the SEM analyses, all independent variables, an interaction term (narrative*promotion focus), and the control variables (political ideology and prior experience about CEO activism) were included after initial evaluations of their effects on endogenous variables, determined through multiple regression analyses as a preliminary test.[8]

Each of the SEM models achieved satisfactory model fit indices, χ^2 = 578.615, df = 205, χ^2/df = 2.823, p <.001, CFI =.98, TLI =.98, RMSEA =.05, 95 % CI [.004,.005], PCLOSE =.98, and SRMR =.04 in terms of the criteria of Hu and Bentler (1999) and of Hair et al. (2010) (see Tables 1–1 and 1–2).

The hypothesis testing revealed that narrative style (NAR) was not statistically directly associated with employee prosocial behaviors (EPBs) neither employee activism supporting the issue (ACT) (*H2a*), β =

[8] A series of ordinary least squares (OLS) multiple regression analyses using STATA 14 was conducted to investigate how the control variables influenced all endogenous variables. In the regression analyses, all independent variables accounted for a significant portion of the variance in endogenous variables: perceived authentic CEO activism (AUT): R^2 =.21, F(4, 908) = 53.42, p <.001; CEO prosocial identity (IDT): R^2 =.73, F(5, 907) = 425.79, p <.001; employee activism supporting an issue (ACT): R^2 =.52, F(6, 906) = 197.16, p <.001; and employee advocacy for CEO activism (ADV): R^2 =.69, F(6, 906) = 322.49, p <.001. The regression analyses consistently revealed that only the prior history of CEO activism factor (AUT: b = 0.26, t = 11.96, IDT: b = 0.05, t = 3.27, ACT: b = 0.24, t = 9.04, and ADV: b = 0.06, t = 3.57) was statistically significant for all endogenous variables; political ideology yielded statistically significant effects only for AUT (b =.10, t = 4.77) and ACT (b = 0.13, t = 5.52). However, the interaction term (narrative*promotion focus) was not statically significant for all endogenous variables (AUT: b = 0.14, t = 0.87, IDT: -b = 0.03, t = −0.17, ACT: b = 0.17, t = 0.80, and ADV: b = 0.05, t = 0.27). Accordingly, the statistically significant paths were included for further analyses in the SEM.

Table 1
The composite reliability and construct validity of the external employee prosocial behavior model that includes perceived CEO activism authenticity (AUT), identification with CEO (IDT), employee activism intention supporting the issue (ACT), and employee advocacy for the CEO activism (ADV) (N = 913).

Latent variables	Measurement items	β	R^2
Perceived CEO Activism Authenticity (AUT)	AUT1: The CEO's actions are genuine.	.87	.75
	AUT2: The CEO's actions preserve what the CEO means to me.	.88	.77
	AUT3: The CEO's actions capture what makes the CEO unique to me.	.88	.78
	AUT4: The CEO's actions are in accordance with the CEO's values and beliefs.	.86	.74
	AUT5: The CEO is being true to himself/herself with his/her actions.	.89	.79
	AUT6: The CEO is standing up for what he/she believes in.	.85	.73
	AUT7: The CEO is a socially responsible person.	.88	.77
	AUT8: The CEO is concerned about improving the well-being of society.	.88	.77
	- Composite Reliability (CR):.96		
	- Average Variance Extracted (AVE):.76		
	- Average Shared Variance (ASV):.65		
CEO Prosocial Identity (IDT)	IDT1: I see the CEO as caring.	.93	.86
	IDT2: I think that the CEO is generous.	.91	.82
	IDT3: I see the CEO as being genuinely concerned about his/her employees.	.93	.86
	- Composite Reliability (CR):.94		
	- Average Variance Extracted (AVE):.85		
	- Average Shared Variance (ASV):.64		
Employee Activism Intention Supporting the Issue (ACT)	ACT1: I would join / belong to an organization that fights for this issue (racial justice and equity).	.90	.81
	ACT2: I would donate money to an organization or group that advocates this issue (racial justice and equity).	.94	.88
	ACT3: I would volunteer my time working (i.e., write petitions, distribute flyers. recruit people. etc.) for an organization that fights for this issue (racial justice and equity).	.94	.88
	ACT4: I would travel for one hour to join in a public rally, protest, or demonstration in support of this issue (racial justice and equity).	.87	.75
	- Composite Reliability (CR):.95		
	- Average Variance Extracted (AVE):.83		
	- Average Shared Variance (ASV):.48		
Employee Advocacy for the CEO Activism (ADV)	ADV1: I would speak favorably about the CEO's action in public.	.92	.84
	ADV2: I would say positive things about the CEO's action to other people.	.93	.87
	ADV3: I would defend the CEO's action when someone says something negative about it.	.92	.85
	ADV4: I would positively tell others about the CEO's action to show them why this matters.	.94	.89
	- Composite Reliability (CR):.96		
	- Average Variance Extracted (AVE):.86		
	- Average Shared Variance (ASV):.64		

Note. β: Standardized Loading Estimate, R^2: Explained Variance. (R): reverse code. Construct validity (standardized loading estimate >.50, convergent validity: AVE >.50, discriminant validity: AVE > ASV), and composite reliability (CR >.70) were successfully established in all measurement items (Hair et al., 2010) Confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) model goodness-of-fit indices met all of the joint criteria by Hu and Bentler (1999) and Hair et al. (2018): χ^2 (135, N =913) = 382.72, p <.001, χ^2/df = 2.83, Comparative Fit Index (CFI) =.99, Tucker Lewis Index (TLI) =.99, Root Mean Square Error of Approximation (RMSEA) =.05, 90 % CI [.040,.050], PCLOSE:.95, and Standardized Root Mean Residual (SRMR) =.03.

Table 2
Hypothesis testing in the proposed SEM model (employee prosocial behaviors) using Bootstrapping (N=5000).

Hs	Parameters			β	S.E.	Critical Ratio (z)	p	95 % CI
Direct Effects								
H2a	NAR	→	ACT	−.04	.02	−1.64	.11	[−.026,.051]
H2b	NAR	→	ADV	−.01	.02	−0.64	.55	[−.045,.021]
H4a	PRO	→	ACT	.01	.02	0.95	.61	[−.026,.051]
H4b	PRO	→	ADV	−.04	.02	−1.95	.05	[−.068, −.005]
H5	AUT	→	IDT	.91	.02	30.28	***	[.025,.110]
H7	NAR	→	AUT	.10	.03	3.15	**	[.046,.146]
H7	PRO	→	AUT	−.02	.03	−0.48	.62	[−.065,.035]
H7a	IDT	→	ACT	.61	.03	19.49	***	[.553,.662]
H7b	IDT	→	ADV	.88	.02	29.14	***	[.844,.917]
	Prior ACT	→	AUT	.44	.03	13.92	***	[.390,.487]
CV	Prior ACT	→	IDT	.06	.03	3.04	**	[.017,.097]
	Prior ACT	→	ACT	.23	.04	8.18	***	[.172,.287]
	Prior ACT	→	ADV	.03	.03	1.32	.29	[−.019,.079]
	POL ID	→	ACT	.13	.02	5.59	***	[.172,.287]
Indirect Effects								
NAR	→ AUT	→ IDT	→ ACT	.05	-	-	**	[.025,.082]
NAR	→ AUT	→ IDT	→ ADV	.08	-	-	**	[.037,.118]
PRO	→ AUT	→ IDT	→ ACT	−.01	-	-	.61	[−.036,.019]
PRO	→ AUT	→ IDT	→ ADV	−.01	-	-	.61	[−.052,.028]

Note. β: Standardized Loading Estimate, S.E.: bootstrap standard errors, CI: confidence intervals, NAR: narrative style, PRO: promotion focused message, AUT: perceived CEO activism authenticity, IDT: CEO prosocial identity, SIL: employee prosocial silence behavior, VOI: employee prosocial voice behavior, Prior ACT: prior history of CEO activism, and POL ID: political ideology. Model fit indices: χ^2 = 578.62, df = 205, χ^2/df = 2.823, p <.001, CFI =.98, TLI =.98, RMSEA =.045, 90 % CI [.040,.049] PCLOSE =.98, and SRMR =.04. ***$p < 0.001$, **$p < 0.01$, *$p < 0.05$.

−.04, p >.05, 95 % CI [-.077,.001] nor employee advocacy for the CEO's activism (ADV) (*H2b*), β = −.01, p >.05, 95 % CI [-.045,.021]. Therefore, H1 was not supported. A promotion-focused message (PRO) was not statistically directly associated with EBPs—neither ACT (*H4a*), β =.01, p >.05, 95 % CI [-.026,.051] nor ADV (*H4b*), β = −.04, p >.05, 95 % CI [-.068,.005]. Accordingly, H2 was not supported.

With regard to H3, the associations between perceived CEO activism authenticity (AUT) and CEO prosocial identity (IDT) were found to be strongly and positively significant in the model: β =.91, p <.001, 95 % CI [.882,.940]. Thus, H5 was supported.

With regard to mediation effects of the employee prosocial sensemaking process (SM) (H4), NAR was directly and significantly associated with AUT in the model, β =.91, p <.001, 95 % CI [.882,.940], while PRO was not significantly related to AUT, β = −.02, p >.05, 95 % CI [-.065,.035]. In addition, IDT was directly associated with EPBs—ACT: β =.61, p <.001, 95 % CI [.553,.662] and ADV: β =.88, p <.05, 95 % CI [.844,.917]. In addition, strong indirect effects of NAR (but not PRO) through SM were found for EPBs—ACT (NAR → SM → ACT): β =.05, p <.01, 95 % CI [.037,.118] and ADV (NAR → SM → ADV): β =.08, p <.01, 95 % CI [.844,.917]. Therefore, H4 was partially supported, as full mediation effects of SM were found only for the effects of NAR on prosocial behaviors only.

As regards the effects of the control variables, prior experience with CEO activism (PRE) was statistically significant for AUT, β =.44, p <.001, 95 % CI [.390,.487], IDT, β =.07, p <.01, 95 % CI [.025,.011], and ACT, β =.23, p <.001, 95 % CI [.172,.287]—but not ADV—while POL was only significantly related to ACT, β =.13, p <.001, 95 % CI [.092,.287] (see Tables 1 and 2 and Fig. 2).

5. Discussion

The purpose of this study was to examine how strategic CEO activism communication can promote employees' engagement in prosocial behaviors through the process of employee prosocial sensemaking. The results revealed that an employee's prosocial sensemaking process—which includes perceived CEO activism authenticity and CEO prosocial identity—functioned as an effective mediator between a narrative style in CEO activism communication and employee prosocial behaviors (activism behaviors and advocacy behaviors). However, due to the mediating role of employee prosocial sensemaking, the strategy of communicating CEO activism using a narrative style and promotion-focused messaging does not directly influence these prosocial behaviors.

This study did not find a direct effect of narrative style in CEO activism communication on any employee prosocial behaviors after the effects of employee prosocial sensemaking are controlled for; in other words, there was a full mediation effect of employee prosocial sensemaking between the narrative style in CEO activism communication and employee prosocial behaviors. This finding indicates that the influence of the prosocial sensemaking process on behavioral change is stronger than the mechanisms of narrative messages, as employees engaging in prosocial sensemaking are more likely to be motivated to critically scrutinize every element of a message even if they are transported into the CEO's activism message by its style. The finding can be explained by the importance of message credibility which facilitates the employee sensemaking process by helping employees engage with the behaviors addressed in the CEO's activism communication (Lee & Koo, 2012). This finding corroborates the powerful mechanism of narrative message, which enables individuals to efficiently process new information through their interpretive schemas or primary frameworks, leading to meaningful interpretation and, in turn, subsequent prosocial behaviors.

Such a strong mediation effect of employee prosocial sensemaking can be understood by the fact that employees who perceive a CEO's activism for social issues as an ethical or moral action that meets or exceeds their expectations are likely to respond with positive evaluations and supportive behavior toward the CEO. This finding confirms the importance of social learning principles (Bandura, 1986) for CEOs' role-modeling behaviors, which inspire employees to support CEOs' actions and behave similarly. In this application of social learning theory to the context of corporate leadership, if a leader engages in actions that prioritize collective interests or undertake risky tasks for the benefit of the collective, employees tend to perceive the CEO's activism on social and political issues as grounded in moral and ethical values (and thus authentic), leading them to exhibit similar prosocial behaviors (Jiang et al., 2019).

Furthermore, this study substantiated the importance of employee prosocial sensemaking in inducing employee prosocial behaviors in the context of CEO activism communication. The study also confirmed the strong direct impact of perceived authenticity and CEO prosocial

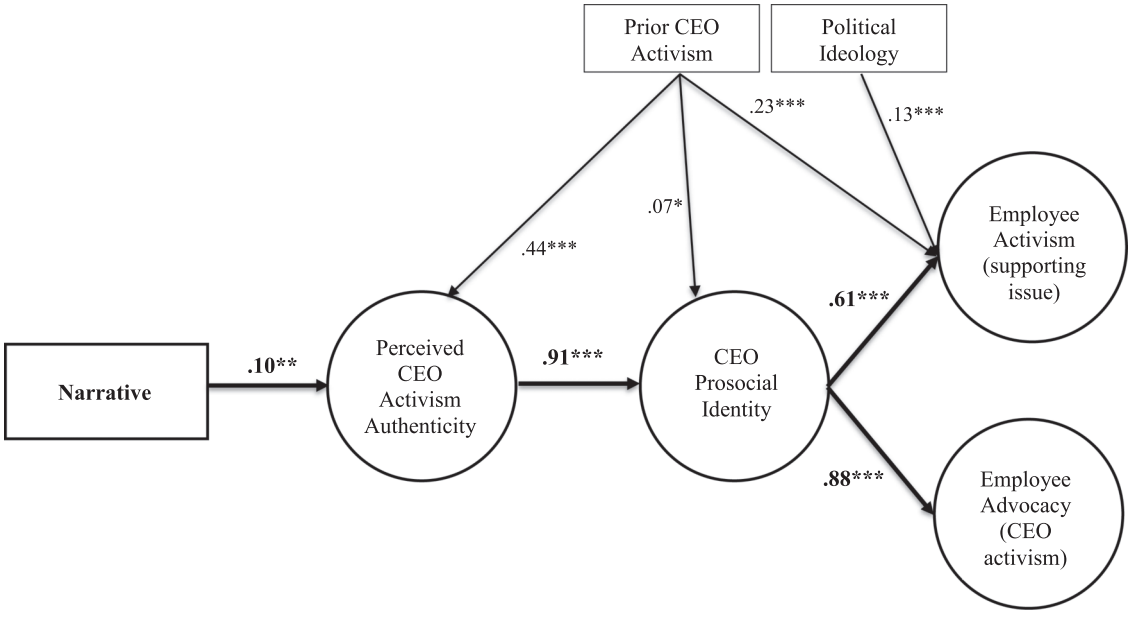


Fig. 2. Bootstrapping (N=5000) results of structural model for hypothesis testing. Narrative (narrative: 1 and non-narrative: 0) was dummy coded. For the sake of brevity and clarity, only statistically significant paths were drawn, and error terms were omitted in the figure. Model fit indices: χ^2 = 578.615, df = 205, χ^2/df = 2.823, p <.001, CFI =.98, TLI =.98, RMSEA =.05; PCLOSE =.98 [0.04, 0.05], and SRMR =.04. ***p < 0.001, **p < 0.01, *p < 0.05.

identity on the process of employee prosocial sensemaking. This finding extends the prosocial sensemaking model to the context of strategic CEO activism communication aiming to promote employees' engagement in prosocial behaviors. In line with previous research (Song & Ferguson, 2023), this finding reveals how the prosocial sensemaking process can be activated, wherein employees perceive the authenticity of a CEO's activism and, in turn, identify the CEO activism as a prosocial action, which is the outcome of effective CEO activism communication. Another plausible explanation could be provided by social identity theory as applied to the context of employee prosocial behaviors, which would propose that employees who have a high degree of shared beliefs between themselves and the CEO's activism are likely to identify the CEO as caring; this enhances their self-concept and, subsequently, their supportive behavioral responses (i.e., prosocial behaviors).

It is also worth noting that a promotion-focused message in CEO activism communication did not directly or indirectly influence employee prosocial behaviors. This finding indicates that the effect of regulatory focus in the message framing may have been overridden by the strong effect of narrative style in CEO activism communication on employee prosocial sensemaking and prosocial behaviors. Employing a narrative style in a message makes the persuasive intent less explicit, thereby suppressing counter-argument and reducing resistance to persuasion (e.g., Dal et al., 2004), but the implicit nature of such persuasion limits the effectiveness of regulatory-focused messages (Lee et al., 2020). Hence, the finding demonstrates that employees effectively make sense of the CEO's message and engage in prosocial behaviors when the CEO's activism message is delivered to them in a narrative style, regardless of the inducement to either seek positive benefits or avoid negative ramifications.

This finding can be further clarified by the different types of regulatory focus among employees. Regulatory focus can be primed via situational factors, such as framed messages (*primed regulatory focus*), or it can be chronic, as part of individuals' stable dispositions (*chronic regulatory focus*) (Idson et al., 2000). Researchers have demonstrated that chronic regulatory focus can be more effective for positive impacts on *the self*, while a primed regulatory focus may be more effective for positive impacts on *others* (Bhatnagar & McKay-Nesbitt, 2016). Previous research has also shown that message effectiveness can be enhanced when the framing of the message matches an individual's regulatory orientation, or chronic regulatory focus (Bullard & Penner, 2017). Since this study examined the impact of CEO activism communication on employees through primed regulatory focus via framed messages, without considering their dispositional regulatory focus, the results might be limited. Providing tailored information in messages with a regulatory-focused framing could lead to significant results: Pham and Avnet's (2004) research found that affective information is more persuasive for individuals with a promotion focus while cognitive information is more persuasion for those with a prevention focus. Nevertheless, more research is needed to determine how the different types of regulatory focus interplay with employee prosocial behaviors.

With respect to the effects of the control variables, the results showed strong effects of a prior history of CEO activism on employee prosocial sensemaking and on prosocial behaviors. As Bandura's (1986) social learning theory and the attitude literature have demonstrated, employees with prior experience with CEO activism may have learned what behavior is expected of them through this experience. This study also found a significant impact of political ideology on employee prosocial behaviors, in line with previous research indicating that conservative or right-leaning individuals are more resistant to corporate messages regarding social issues such as climate change and gender equality (Marschlich & Bernet, 2024). These findings suggest that researchers should consider prior experience with CEO activism and political ideology when exploring employee engagement around social issues.

6. Conclusion and implications

In terms of theoretical contributions, this study extends the scholarship on strategic communication strategies to CEO activism communication and its relation to employee prosocial behaviors. Scholarship has begun to explore CEO sociopolitical activism as a means of effective leadership, along with how it may impact (current and prospective) employees' perceptions of the organization (Appels, 2023). While CEO activism may be grounded in a leader's personal values and beliefs, one must consider the potential support—or lack thereof—from various publics, namely employees and customers (Hambrick & Wowak, 2021). However, previous research has predominantly focused on the impact of the latter on external publics, such as consumers and investors (Ji & Tao, 2024), or on organizational outcomes (Jin et al., 2024). Therefore, this study advances the extant literature in strategic communication, especially around employee engagement with CEO activism, by providing empirical evidence that utilizing a strategic narrative style in CEO activism communication can increase employees' prosocial sensemaking, which in turn promotes their prosocial behaviors. The results in this study thus enhance the theoretical development of strategic leadership communication in public relations as it relates to CEO activism and employee prosocial behaviors.

In this regard, the current study establishes a significant foundation for the importance of applying a narrative style in strategic CEO activism communication. The findings of this study elucidate how employees—as readers and viewers—can immerse themselves cognitively into a CEO's story while making sense of and then responding to the activism in the narrative content (Xu & Kochigina, 2021). The study indicates that getting employees absorbed in the CEO's narrative message can motivate deeper processing of the CEO's activism, facilitating their perception of the authenticity of CEO activism (e.g., *the CEO's actions are genuine*) and identifying the CEO as prosocial. This, in turn, leads to employees engaging in supportive behaviors that are consistent with the intent of the activism messages (e.g., transportation theory). In this sense, narrative strategies have already been theoretically found to fit well with CSR initiatives, offering an engaging way to convey corporate character (Boukes & LaMarre, 2021). Extending this insight to corporate leaders' strategic communication, this study recommends examining the important role of narrative style in theoretical development for effective CEO activism communication that induces employee prosocial behaviors, which include suggesting constructive ideas voluntarily participating in collective actions for social issues and advocating for the CEO's activism.

This study also adds the underlying mechanism of employees' prosocial sensemaking to the growing body of knowledge on employee prosocial behaviors. In line with previous research on the employee sensemaking process (Grant et al., 2008), this study substantiates that employees are likely to engage in prosocial behaviors after making sense of CEO activism communication, which they do through perceived CEO authenticity and identification of the CEO as caring. Due to the voluntary nature and the necessity of going beyond formal job requirements and expectations that employee prosocial behaviors entail, motivating employees to engage in such behaviors is challenging, but organizations can gain social and economic benefits if they do. To this end, this study provides a foundation for further research that considers employee sensemaking as an important mediator bridging CEO activism communication and employee prosocial behaviors.

In terms of practical contributions, this study underscores implementing strategic CEO activism communication in a way that reflects CEOs' authenticity and increases their identification as prosocial by their employees. A growing number of CEOs of large corporations have engaged in activist communication and behaviors, and pressures and expectations for CEOs to speak out on current issues have been rising (Edelman Connected Crisis, 2022). Against this backdrop, CEOs and corporations will continue to speak out and engage in activist behavior. However, CEO activism can be a double-edged sword because CEOs

taking actions on social issues may build loyalty with employees but may also inadvertently make employees feel alienated (Larcker et al., 2018). Thus, CEO activism is a risky and tricky business, with many receiving backlash for getting involved in such issues. Nevertheless, CEOs' activism and corporate advocacy behaviors will continue to be fueled by pressure from employees—particularly those from younger generations (e.g., Gen Z), who believe companies have a responsibility to take a stand on controversial societal issues (Coman et al., 2022).

To this end, the current study provides important insights into how organizations can benefit from strategic CEO activism, which can enhance organizational effectiveness and expand responsible business practices. The nature of CEO activism—i.e., taking a definitive stance on social issues and highlighting the CEO's positive contribution to society—could actually help mitigate skepticism among employees around social actions that is caused by ambiguous corporate CSR practices (Boukes & LaMarre, 2021). Thus, this study encourages communication practitioners to help their organizations or corporate leaders to strategically communicate their activism (such as by using narrative-style messages), to reduce backlashes stemming from employees' skepticism of corporate social actions and to promote employees' engagement in prosocial behaviors.

However, the findings do not mean to suggest that all corporations, such as Fortune 500 companies, take a stand on all controversial social issues. In fact, corporate and leader messages around socio-political concerns (e.g., Black Lives Matter) can lead to confusion and discontentment particularly if those actions misalign with first-hand experiences by employees (Harper, 2020). Additionally, while corporate leaders are pushed to attend to the interests of all stakeholder groups, doing so can cause conflict among a polarized workforce and society (Taylor, 2024). The reality is that CEO activism is truly the new normal (Gelles, 2018), and in an age of increased transparency, organizations must be strategic in their communication and control the narrative, particularly regarding their prosocial or activist behavior. Employees may play a vital role in determining corporate advocacy—being involved in such conversations and setting organizational priorities (Taylor, 2024).

6.1. Limitations and Suggestions for Future Research

This study acknowledges its limitations. First, this study did not include internal communication practices, such as empowering leadership or communal relationships with employees, which could influence employee prosocial behaviors (Dong et al., 2023; Li et al., 2017). Future research should investigate how specific leadership styles (e.g., authentic or transformational) and/or types of relationships with employees (e.g., exchange or communal) can interplay with message strategies and employee prosocial sensemaking.

Second, this study did not include employee prosocial behaviors such as prosocial silence and prosocial voice (Van Dyne et al., 2003). Researchers have stressed the distinction between external and internal supportive behaviors by employees, as employees can engage in recommending and defending the organization to people outside the workplace as well as to their colleagues within the organization (Lee, 2022; Thelen, 2020). Future research is suggested to explore how CEO activism could influence internal employee prosocial behaviors.

Third, this study's experimental design serves as a limitation due to testing hypothetically created CEO messages, rather than actual examples and statements from leaders. Future research should consider real-world examples and scenarios in order to further explore employee perceptions and reactions to the issue itself, as well as their own leader's sense of and communication of activism. These statements certainly present nuances and qualities beyond narrative vs. non-narrative, and promotion vs. prevention-based messages. Thus, the use of real examples in future research would allow for further examination of this rhetoric. Additionally, future work may consider a qualitative approach for more of a discourse analysis of statements, or interviews and focus groups to explore employee reactions and discussion.

Relatedly, this study's measurement of the perceived CEO activism authenticity may be challenged by other research, as it assessed perceptions of a hypothetical company's hypothetical CEO without employees' knowledge of the CEO's values and beliefs. Perceived authenticity is defined as "the extent to which one acts in accord with the true self, without explicit considerations of others" (Shen & Kim, 2012, p. 373). Congruence in the CEO's values, beliefs, and actions is a critical element for perceived authenticity of CEO communication (Men, 2021). Therefore, future research should consider a CEO's communication attributes when interacting with employees to better evaluate perceived CEO authenticity in activism communication.

In addition, the effects of regulatory focus in framing messages in this study could vary. Previous research has indicated that individuals' motivational orientation, induced by message framing, can be changed by other factors, such as different framings (gain vs. loss) (Lin & Shen, 2012) or individuals' self-views (Kim, 2006). Future research should explore different framings of CEO activism messages and consider employees' character dispositions to yield richer results.

Lastly, this study did not consider employees' involvement in social issues or company CSR practices, although such involvement can also induce employee prosocial behaviors (Pressgrove and Kim, 2018). Future research should examine how employee involvement could influence their prosocial sensemaking and prosocial behaviors in relation to CEO activism communication.

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Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare the following financial interests/personal relationships which may be considered as potential competing interests Young Kim reports financial support was provided by The Pennsylvania State University. If there are other authors, they declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Appendix. Conditions of CEO Activism Statements by Narrative vs. Non-Narrative and Promotion- vs. Prevention-Focused Messages

Condition A: Narrative & Promotion-Focused Message

Initiatives to Promote Racial Equity and Justice

I am writing about an important initiative that will lead to greater opportunities for both the company and society. I am passionate about the racial justice issue. My parents raised me to believe that all people are equal, that diversity is a reflection of our common humanity. Yet despite my parents' optimistic view, we know that all people are not treated equally and that the problem of systemic racism is very real. I have witnessed friends, colleagues, and community members suffer as a result of racial injustice which has affected me deeply. I believe that building a more just and equitable world is urgent work that demands collaboration, commitment, and a common sense of purpose.

To promote racial equity and justice in our society, I, as the CEO, take a strategic and long-term approach to this topic in a way that fights racism and works to drive sustainable change. Today I decided to pledge $5 million to support nonprofit organizations that advance social justice, beginning with a $2 million donation to the NAACP (The National Association for the Advancement of Colored People) to further their

longstanding work promoting social justice by

ensuring equality and racial equity through their advocacy and education programs.

I believe that this initiative is an important step in our journey to advance our diversity, equity, and inclusion efforts, while holding ourselves accountable for addressing areas of opportunity. It will be joined by partners across a broad range of industries and backgrounds — from students to teachers, developers to entrepreneurs, and community organizers to justice advocates — working together to empower communities that have borne the brunt of racism and discrimination for far too long.

This critical work will ensure that we continue to promote better outcomes while investing in our teammates and the communities we proudly serve and call home.

Condition B: Narrative & Prevention-Focused Message

Initiatives to Prevent Racial Injustice and Inequity

I am writing about an important initiative that will lead to greater opportunities for both the company and society. I am passionate about the racial justice issue. My parents raised me to believe that all people are equal, that diversity is a reflection of our common humanity. Yet despite my parents' optimistic view, we know that all people are not treated equally and that the problem of systemic racism is very real. I have witnessed friends, colleagues, and community members suffer as a result of racial injustice which has affected me deeply. I believe that building a more just and equitable world is urgent work that demands collaboration, commitment, and a common sense of purpose.

To prevent systematic racial injustice and inequity in our society, I, as the CEO, take a strategic and long-term approach to this topic in a way that fights racism and works to drive sustainable change. Today I decided to pledge $5 million to support nonprofit organizations that advance social justice, beginning with a $2 million donation to the NAACP (The National Association for the Advancement of Colored People) to further their longstanding work preventing social injustice by eliminating disparities and racial discrimination through their advocacy and education programs.

I believe that this initiative is an important step in our journey to prevent racial injustice and inequity, while holding ourselves accountable for addressing areas of opportunity. It will be joined by partners across a broad range of industries and backgrounds — from students to teachers, developers to entrepreneurs, and community organizers to justice advocates — working together to protect communities that have borne the brunt of racism and discrimination for far too long.

This critical work will ensure that we continue to prevent systematic racism and inequality while investing in our teammates and the communities we proudly serve and call home.

Condition C: Non-Narrative & Promotion-Focused Message

Initiatives to Promote Racial Equity and Justice

We are committed to diversity, inclusion, and equity in all areas of our business and celebrate the unique perspectives and backgrounds that make us stronger. Two of our core values are Respect and Integrity, which are integral in how we conduct business. Yet despite our commitment, we know that all people are not treated equally and that the problem of systemic racism is very real. We believe that building a more just and equitable world is urgent work that demands collaboration, commitment, and a common sense of purpose.

To promote racial equity and justice in our society, we, as a company, take a strategic and long-term approach to this topic in a way that fights racism and works to drive sustainable change. Today we decided to pledge $5 million to support nonprofit organizations that advance social justice, beginning with a $2 million donation to the NAACP (The National Association for the Advancement of Colored People) to further their longstanding work promoting social justice by ensuring equality and racial equity through their advocacy and education programs.

We believe that this initiative is an important step in our journey to advance our diversity, equity, and inclusion efforts, while holding ourselves accountable for addressing areas of opportunity. It will be joined by partners across a broad range of industries and backgrounds — from students to teachers, developers to entrepreneurs, and community organizers to justice advocates — working together to empower communities that have borne the brunt of racism and discrimination for far too long.

This critical work will ensure that we continue to promote better outcomes while investing in our teammates and the communities we proudly serve and call home.

Condition D: Non-Narrative & Prevention-Focused Message

Initiatives to Prevent Racial Injustice and Inequity

We are committed to diversity, inclusion, and equity in all areas of our business and celebrate the unique perspectives and backgrounds that make us stronger. Two of our core values are Respect and Integrity, which are integral in how we conduct business. Yet despite our commitment, we know that all people are not treated equally and that the problem of systemic racism is very real. We believe that building a more just and equitable world is urgent work that demands collaboration, commitment, and a common sense of purpose.

To prevent systematic racial injustice and inequity in our society, we, as a company, take a strategic and long-term approach to this topic in a way that fights racism and works to drive sustainable change. Today we decided to pledge $5 million to support nonprofit organizations that advance social justice, beginning with a $2 million donation to the NAACP (The National Association for the Advancement of Colored People) to further their longstanding work preventing social injustice by eliminating disparities and racial discrimination through their advocacy and education programs.

We believe that this initiative is an important step in our journey to prevent racial injustice and inequity, while holding ourselves accountable for addressing areas of opportunity. It will be joined by partners across a broad range of industries and backgrounds — from students to teachers, developers to entrepreneurs, and community organizers to justice advocates — working together to protect communities that have borne the brunt of racism and discrimination for far too long.

This critical work will ensure that we continue to prevent systematic racism and inequality while investing in our teammates and the communities we proudly serve and call home.

Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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